tion, abundance and rebirth, often associated with wildness. The sharp features of these classical models, the folds of Dionysius's fine drapery and sandals, are echoed in the figure of Gandhara's Bodhisattva Maitreya (represented by a printed image), although his meditative poise sets him apart. Together, Apollo and Dionysius represented the "balance of opposites". The alluring Aphrodite, goddess of love, emerges nude from her bath, protecting her modesty, as it were, from roving eyes. She brings to mind the sensuous Didarganj Yakshi carved out of Chunar sandstone, her feminine charm enhanced by the lustrous polish. The Yajna Varaha, the massive red sandstone sculpture (900-1099 CE) of Vishnu incarnated as a wild boar who rescued mother earth Bhu-devi from deluge and destruction, holds centrestage.

Hapy is the Egyptian god responsible for the flooding of the Nile that left behind silt ideal for agriculture. His sandstone sculpture from the British Museum symbolises prosperity resulting from abundant agricultural produce. Ganga, the holiest of rivers to Hindus, on the other hand, is worshipped as the goddess of purification and forgiveness. The two Assyrian panels from the CSMVS holding represent the civilisation that flourished in Mesopotamia. These panels provide an insight into ancient Assyrian culture, their power structure and their beliefs. There are, besides fragments of two of the Seven Wonders of the Ancient World—a lion's head from the Temple of Artemis and Greeks fighting Amazons—a frieze from the tomb of Mausolus.

"Here for the first time is the ancient world seen and interrogated not from a European point of view but from the standpoint of India," says Neil MacGregor, advisor to the Getty's sharing collections programme and former director of the National Gallery, London. ■

Soumitra Das

ART

OF SUNPRINTS AND SULLIED RIVERS

Lost River, Hari Katragadda's debut show at Cymroza Art Gallery in Mumbai, is an artistic adventure as well as a strong social statement



There's nothing so arterial to the Hindu way of life as the river Ganga and its spiritual symbolism. And yet, for something that stands so much for purity, the physical form of the river is one of the planet's most polluted. This is the confluence of thought at which Hari Katragadda's debut solo show, titled *Lost River*, attempts to find meaning through four bodies of work based on cyanotype technique, often dubbed the 'blueprints of photography'. Curated by acclaimed art expert Ranjit Hoskote, the pathbreaking photographs will be on view at Cymroza Art Gallery during the 11th edition of the four-day extravaganza that is the Mumbai Gallery Weekend (January 11-14) and beyond, until February 17.

While the 'lost river' was the mysterious and near-mythical Saraswati, the phrase used here is a telling tale of how the idea of the Ganga is somehow getting lost in its reality. Katragadda, a transmedia artist, who usually works with multiple photographic techniques, drawing, painting, video and the artist book, has decided to harness cyanotype for his debut solo exhibition, a method that involves registering images on chemically coated paper by exposing it to sunlight. These prints have allowed him to bring the contaminated river directly into contact with the photographic plate. For example, his '24 Foam Impressions' combines a grid of cyanotype prints that were made every hour for a 24-hour period



THE PHRASE 'LOST RIVER' HERE IS A TELLING TALE OF HOW THE IDEA OF THE GANGA IS GETTING LOST IN ITS REALITY

by exposing the print to the flow of the Ganga and developing it in the water of the river at the point where the Nagwa Nala, one of Varanasi's main drains, pours into it! This is not only mastery over a technique but the ability to truly capture the 'decisive moment' in a very novel way. 'The Shimmer', an accompanying video installation, captures the many moods of the sullied river, sometimes peaceful, turbulent at others, but always disturbing with its accurate portrayal.

"I've followed Hari's versatile practice for a number of years," says Hoskote. "I respond strongly to his cyanotype work because it returns to the earliest days of photography, to the elemental interplay of light, chemical surface and water to produce images.... This is work that is profoundly beautiful and profoundly critical at the same time."

Hoskote hopes that the exhibition will draw viewers "into a pensive reflection on how our civilisational hypocrisy has exacted vast environmental and humanitarian costs". He observes, "We pollute, brutally, the rivers we claim to worship. Our enshrined practice of caste apartheid results in the inhuman treatment of the vulnerable subaltern communities, who are pushed into misery, squalor and lack."

'Shroud', an installation based on a cyanotype made with a bier, flowers, ash, bones and water collected at the Manikarnika Ghat in Varanasi on a shroud is a deliberate conjunction of the cult of purity and the empirical fact of pollution—essentially a critique of caste. "In these waters, either everyone is pure, or no one is," is the apt summation, the writing on the wall, as it were. ■

Priya Pathiyan